Spykman's claims challenged Alfred Thayer Mahan's famous assertion in *The Influence of Seapower upon History* that control of the high seas rightly was the great goal of the maritime powers.[15] Instead of looking at the vast global maritime highway, as Mahan did, Spykman instead concentrated on the areas where most of the global population lived, where production was most concentrated, and where trade was most intensely conducted. In a 1943 *Foreign Affairs* article, "The Round World and the Winning of the Peace," Mackinder himself had joined Spykman, modifying his earlier position.[16] Mackinder, like Spykman, now emphasized the importance of the rimlands and their marginal seas. The great naval battles of World War II, except for the Battle of the Atlantic, the Coral Sea, and Midway, were indeed fought largely in the inner seas of Europe and Asia.

Control of the inner seas was not a new military concept. It explains the decades-long war waged by the British Royal Navy against Napoleon's ships in the English Channel and French littoral waters, as well as the Imperial Japanese Navy's reduction of the Chinese and Russian fleets in the Yellow Sea in both 1894 and 1904, giving it control over access to Korea and China. As both these examples also point out, the struggle for control of the inner seas is often the first step to a larger contest over the rimlands, and this maritime-based competition can last years before a move is made on land or the issue is decided by opposing armies.

Technological advances since the Great War had come fully to fruition by the 1940s, and Spykman struggled to expand his thesis to incorporate the most modern type of combat: aerial warfare. Command of the skies and the ability to effect devastating results on the ground from the air only became a feasible military capability in World War II. The ferocious aerial warfare of the Battle of Britain was one example of the struggle for the inner seas being expanded to the realm of aerospace. Indeed, due to the limitations of 1940s-era aircraft, aerial warfare was almost wholly restricted to the littoral and rimlands regions. The objective, however, remained the same: control the maritime/aerial commons that give access to the rimlands.